

of the soon-to-be-huge online consumer market. This means that as long as this massive growth phase, or at least the potential for growth, lasts, e-commerce sites would be more than willing to continue offering benefits like huge discounts, cash-on-delivery (CoD), long return periods, and free shipping, even if some of these facilities negatively affect their revenues.

While that is indeed good for consumers, it also means that the industry's inexperience might lead to bad experiences, either before, during or even after the purchase. Because of a number of parties involved in a single transaction (online retailer, actual supplier, payment gateway, credit card company, bank, courier company, buyer), things can go wrong anywhere, which means that you, as a consumer, need to be prepared to tackle such issues effectively.

Below, we list out various scenarios where things can and do go wrong, and offer remedies for each situation:

What can go wrong?

The product you purchased is different from the one that was advertised

Not being able to touch the product or try it on before buying is one of the major drawbacks of online shopping. You need to wait till the product arrives to be able to see and use it.

A physical store gives you the liberty to inspect an item before you buy, whereas a product shipped from an e-commerce site might be defective and you won't even be aware of it until you make the purchase. Another possibility is that the delivered product ends up looking totally different from what was advertised on the website.

In fact, there have been quite a few incidents where customers ended up with a completely different product being delivered to them, bearing absolutely no resemblance to the original product listing.

In such cases getting your order replaced usually results in a huge hassle. Not all consumers have the patience to convince the seller regarding the reason for replacement and wait till their calls are answered or emails responded to.

The product arrives in a damaged condition

Delivery of the product is probably the hardest area to deal with, from both the company and the customer's point of view. There are certain companies that offer refunds for damages, if any, but some amount of caution is advised